Self-Rulership Through Abundance

A Personal Philosophy of Freedom, Responsibility, and Peaceful Nonparticipation

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Purpose

My objective is not to escape society, reject human cooperation, or achieve complete self-sufficiency.

I want to design a life in which I can meet my needs, exercise meaningful choices, accept responsibility for my actions, and participate with other people voluntarily.

I seek abundance across multiple forms of capital rather than dependence on financial income alone.

My guiding objective is simple:

To create enough abundance, resilience, and capability that I am increasingly free to choose what I do, rather than being compelled by circumstances to do what I must.

That freedom must also leave room for enjoyment, relationships, curiosity, and rest.

1. Self-rulership

I believe individuals should retain the greatest practical and moral authority possible over their own lives.

I distinguish between rules and rulers. I recognize that rules, agreements, boundaries, and accountability are necessary for people to coexist.

However, I do not believe that an institution automatically acquires moral authority over an individual simply because that person was born within its jurisdiction.

I question the assumption that citizenship, residence, or receiving public benefits constitutes meaningful consent to a political social contract.

I recognize that government possesses enforceable legal authority. That fact does not, by itself, resolve whether every exercise of that authority is morally justified.

2. Peaceful nonparticipation

My decision not to vote is an expression of personal integrity, not a strategy to influence election results.

I do not require others to share that decision, and I recognize that people can participate politically without necessarily endorsing every aspect of the institutions involved.

My preferred response to unwanted political authority is to reduce my exposure to it through practical choices.

Rather than dedicating my life to changing political leadership, I focus on developing alternatives that reduce my dependence on political decisions.

I will use existing institutions when necessary and recognize the risks of refusing to comply with enforceable laws.

I distinguish legal compliance from moral agreement.

My approach is peaceful, practical, and oriented toward building rather than confrontation.

3. Responsibility before dependence

I prefer to retain the knowledge, tools, and ability to maintain the systems on which my life depends.

This does not mean I can always do a better job than a professional or that doing everything myself is efficient.

It means that when I understand and maintain a system, I gain the ability to diagnose problems, learn from failures, and improve its operation.

I accept additional work and maintenance when the resulting capability is valuable to me.

However, independence must not become an endless obligation to build, repair, and improve.

The purpose of capability is greater freedom, not perpetual labor.

4. Voluntary cooperation and mutual responsibility

I value community and want to contribute positively to the people around me.

I prefer relationships based on voluntary cooperation, reciprocity, trust, and mutually understood commitments.

I believe freely entered contracts can create legitimate, enforceable obligations.

When disputes arise, I favor negotiation and mediation before litigation or compulsory enforcement.

I recognize that people have the freedom to withdraw from voluntary relationships and that their choices may affect trust, goodwill, and future opportunities.

I am willing to contribute more than is strictly required when doing so preserves valuable relationships or improves the stability of my community.

Being independent does not mean refusing help. My preference is to avoid unnecessary dependence while remaining capable of giving and receiving assistance.

5. Freedom to innovate and responsibility for outcomes

I favor regulatory approaches that establish legitimate objectives while leaving individuals room to choose how to accomplish them.

I prefer performance-based standards over unnecessary prescriptions of specific technologies, materials, or methods.

The burden of regulation should be proportionate to the severity and likelihood of harm, the scale of an activity, and the consequences of failure.

I generally favor accountability for actual harm over requiring advance permission for every activity.

At the same time, I recognize that some harms can be irreversible, difficult to detect, or imposed on people who did not consent to the risk.

My own confidence that a system is safe is not necessarily sufficient evidence. Independent evaluation, testing, and cooperation may sometimes be justified.

I accept responsibility for correcting harm I cause to others.

6. Abundance across eight forms of capital

I do not equate wealth exclusively with money.

I want to build abundance in financial, material, living, social, intellectual, experiential, cultural, and spiritual capital.

A productive food forest, functional infrastructure, practical knowledge, strong relationships, and the ability to exchange surplus all contribute to resilience.

My goal is not to produce every resource I consume.

It is to produce enough value in selected areas that I can voluntarily obtain other necessities without being compelled into employment or arrangements I do not want.

Abundance should also be shareable.

I would rather demonstrate the possibilities of this lifestyle through observable results than attempt to persuade others through ideology.

I acknowledge the labor, costs, limitations, and failures involved. The example is meaningful only when those costs are visible too.

7. Scarcity and institutional dependence

I believe some scarcity experienced in modern society is created or intensified by institutional arrangements, financial obligations, regulatory barriers, and concentrations of economic power.

I do not assume these conditions were necessarily created through malicious intent. Many may have emerged through historical incentives, accumulated decisions, or attempts to solve earlier problems.

I also recognize that genuine physical scarcity exists. Energy, time, land, materials, and labor are finite.

My working hypothesis is that thoughtful design, local production, voluntary exchange, and practical knowledge can eliminate some unnecessary dependencies and create greater material and nonmaterial abundance.

This hypothesis should remain open to evidence and revision.

8. Practical sovereignty

My homestead is the physical expression of these principles.

I have chosen to accept substantial responsibility for energy, infrastructure, land management, food production, and maintenance.

I deliberately live where my desired activities can be pursued with comparatively fewer restrictions and dependencies.

I recognize that complete independence is neither achievable nor necessary.

I still rely on markets, public infrastructure, legal institutions, manufactured goods, and relationships with other people.

I evaluate these dependencies according to their costs, reliability, maintenance burden, and effect on my ability to choose.

The goal is not zero dependence. It is a manageable, deliberate balance.

9. The limits of independence

My philosophy must remain subject to the same scrutiny I apply to outside institutions.

I can mistake personal preference for universal principle.

I can underestimate the time and labor required to maintain independent systems.

I can overestimate my own technical judgment or underestimate risks borne by others.

Voluntary communities can develop informal hierarchies, exclusion, and coercive pressures without formal government.

And an emphasis on self-reliance can become counterproductive if I reject useful cooperation merely to preserve an identity built around independence.

I therefore intend to distinguish what I personally prefer from what I can demonstrate is effective, and what I consider morally justified from what I believe other people should be required to do.

10. My definition of success

Success is not the completion of every project or the elimination of every dependency.

It is developing a durable, productive, and sufficiently abundant life in which my wife and I can choose how to spend more of our time.

It includes the ability to work meaningfully, continue learning, improve our surroundings, help neighbors, maintain valued relationships, and enjoy ordinary life.

It also requires knowing when not to build another system.

I want the homestead to serve our lives rather than requiring our lives to serve the homestead.

Freedom is not having nothing left to do. It is having meaningful choices about what is worth doing.

11. Questions that remain open

This philosophy is an evolving personal framework, not a completed political theory.

Questions worth revisiting include:

- What ultimately legitimizes legal enforcement when consent is absent?
- How should conflicts involving shared resources and potentially irreversible harm be resolved?
- How can voluntary communities prevent informal concentrations of power?
- How should I measure the actual costs of independence, including my time?
- Which dependencies are productive, and which unnecessarily constrain my choices?
- When does building additional capability stop creating meaningful freedom?

I do not need final answers to every question to live according to my present understanding.

But I should remain willing to reconsider my assumptions when experience and evidence warrant it.

Closing principle

I choose peaceful nonparticipation not because I expect everyone else to follow my example, but because I want my actions to remain consistent with my understanding of legitimate authority, personal responsibility, and voluntary cooperation.

I seek to create abundance rather than merely accumulate resources, capability rather than dependency, and relationships based on choice rather than compulsion.

I recognize the practical constraints of the society in which I live.

Within those constraints, I intend to build a life that progressively expands my freedom to choose.

The destination is not complete independence. It is sufficient independence to live well, contribute voluntarily, and enjoy the life I am building.